

Pressure & Stress

Character **First**

GOALS MONTH 2

- You recognize the physical and mental signals of stress in yourself
- You master at least one breathing technique to regulate activation
- You can name the difference between problem-focused and emotion-focused coping

Feeling pressure is normal. Every top athlete feels it. What makes the difference is how you deal with it. This worksheet helps you discover how your body and mind respond to stress.

EXERCISE 1 — BOX BREATHING

1 Box Breathing Log

Practice Box Breathing at least 3 times this month before training or a match. Fill in after each time: how did you feel before and after?

DATE / SITUATION

BEFORE (1-10)

AFTER (1-10)

EXERCISE 2 — STRESS DIARY

2 Stress Diary

Write three things after your next match: what did you feel, what did you think, and what did you do?

What did I feel? (physical and emotional)

What did I think?

What did I do? (how did I respond to the pressure?)

EXERCISE 3 — WORST CASE BEST CASE

3 Worst Case Best Case

Think of an upcoming situation that makes you nervous. Write the three scenarios.

Worst Case

Best Case

Most Likely

"Pressure is a privilege — it only comes to those who earn it."

Billie Jean King — 39x Grand Slam Champion

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SCIENTIFIC FOUNDATION — EVIDENCE PYRAMID

Systematic Review Crocker et al. (2015) — 92 studies: flexible coping strategies show strongest link to performance and well-being in youth sport.

RCT Balban et al. (2023) — cyclic breathing significantly reduces stress vs. mindfulness. *Cell Reports Medicine*.

Qualitative Hanton et al. (2009) — stress response becomes facilitating or debilitating based on interpretation, not intensity.

GUIDANCE PER EXERCISE

- 1 Box Breathing:** Together as group before training. Circle, eyes closed. "In... 2,3,4. Hold... Out... Wait..." 4 times. Then: "What do you notice?"
- 2 Stress Diary:** Individual and private. Say explicitly: "This diary is for you alone." After 2 weeks: "Who noticed patterns?"
- 3 Worst Case Best Case:** In pairs. Coach asks one question: "Has your Worst Case ever actually happened?" Relativizing is the goal.

COACH TIPS FOR THIS THEME

Tip 1: Actively normalize stress: "Every pro feels this. Not a weakness."

Tip 2: Use Box Breathing at time-outs. 30 seconds breathing before tactics = better information retention.

Tip 3: Players who never show stress: check in individually. May be apathy.

⚠ Beware: "You should be able to handle this" amplifies exactly the stress you're trying to reduce. Use: "What do you need to stay calm?"

TIMING

- ☐ Group Box Breathing: 8 minutes
- ☐ Explanation of stress and coping: 5 minutes
- ☐ Individual worksheet: 10 minutes
- ☐ Worst Case Best Case in pairs: 10 minutes
- ☐ Group reflection: 7 minutes